What You See Ain't What You Get

A Program Starter by Tiembé Maboola



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This collection of poetry is intended to peel back the way assumptions color our interactions; what we see and what we think we see are often very different. Through exploring the emotions of attraction and alienation, each of these poems offer a different perspective on what it means to judge a situation or a person based on looks alone. Acknowledging the limitations of our perceptions is the first step to improving how we understand, relate, and connect to each other. The voices in these poems are intended to showcase different points of view and a variety of cultural and racial backgrounds. The conversation on race is such a volatile subject that one point of view seemed inappropriate. However, if the student prefers to speak from one ethnic vantage point, pronouns may be changed to suit the speaker's intention.

The Power of Vulnerability

At first,
perhaps you will allow the invisible forces of nature
that attract opposites and bend light
to persuade you into thinking you stand a chance.

Glance.

Gaze an opportunity to charm your way in.
You wish to claim my heart as yours.
The way to a man's heart is through his stomach, you surmise
So the way to a woman's heart must be through her thighs.

Perhaps.

You saw a challenge.
Or maybe I'm not the prize
you had your eyes on
I display nothing delicate outwardly
And even though my inner battles are fought quietly
The words
Conveying nothing but naked truth
I let drip from my mouth and evaporate into your ears
undress the more I speak to you

I will not apologize
For being bold and passionate,
right and wrong

I won't attempt to lure you with my looks.
I won't gimmick you with flirtatious gestures,
or charm you with superfluous words.
I expect the same in return.

For over time I have come to learn
that first impressions are as finite as love at first sight.

And these bones that frame my flaws,
holding up these walls. I keep
hiding a heart that somehow
always finds a way to my sleeve.

Its strings are being re-tuned
by the chief musician,
as rare birds with broken wings are.

Come.

Be sure to listen to her song.
She doesn't sing it for just anyone.

Show.

Show me your ugly,
Your sentimental
Your messy
Your blunt
Your just plain silly
Show me your weak
Your indecisive
Your cheeky/strange/repressed/impressions of what it means to be
human
Because that's all there is to me

And if you dare to love this bird rare

Know.

Having nothing but mere metaphors to hide behind
Sitting at the edge of the chasm of life's peak, I
Admit.

Admit.

That I am not all that I am,
But what I try to be.
Try not to be.

Speak.

My truth –
spilled out in the form of a prayer in poetry,
where I choose to undress my pride,
and risk it all to confide what's confined inside the holy temple of my mind –
it is my Bethesda

Weak.

Yet I am strong for I have discovered sufficiency
and the grace of the trinity inside of me.
The soul, the body, the mind.

I no longer behold through rose tinted lenses
Life becomes…
The things that live on are the mountains yet to be moved

Transformed.

The truth
unchanged in the light
unbent by the forces of nature:
I am an unfiltered photograph,
I am analyzing closely.
I am a piece of art.

Why are we so afraid
of being that which we naturally are?
Indecisive, unreliable, messy matted tangles of emotion
Wrapped in skin that protects us from the outside world
And connects us to it.

Human.

With a history of scars
And assorted shames
That have added layers to my skin,
Callous
To my frame.
But this vulnerability,
it is tender but not liable;
it is neither slander nor libel.
It is its own kind of strength,
Reminding me that even though I've seen better
The days ahead will be greater.
And that's not a lie,
It's a promise.

Honest.

Because some days,
A voice is a well in the desert
and within each long pause,
Between answering life's questions,
I'm swallowing my pride.
And showing

an ancient art form passed down of African daughters.
Woven together by divine hands.
This is a tapestry of bruised beauty

So keep glancing
Keep watching
Because the parts of me that are worth more
Looking at and loving
The parts of me unravel
only with slow work
Steady hands
And long, psalms of silence.

White Noise

It happened by accident (if you believe in such things).

Age 8

Reaching for the crossbeam on the monkey bars at the same time, our bodies collided. Like two galaxies, we were dust and atoms, gravity and momentum. And after we met, we collapsed into a pile of arms and legs. Awoken by the force of our discovery.

As the skin of our elbows and knees bloomed into bruises, we compared – how his looked like a plum-colored dahlia and mine a boring pink rose.

I wondered out loud, does that mean our blood is different colored? Probably, he said.

His came from Mexico; from rivers of music and valleys of heat; he said his grandma was stained the color of mesa from making tortillas; his mother was tinted the color of earth from working in the garden; his father was bathed in the color of blood from the last time he saw him.

And I felt very different from him.

My father, my mother, my grandmother had no tint or shade or hue. I made the mistake of thinking that meant I had no stains.

Age 11

By the time I found my voice, it was changing. Cracking and popping like knuckles under stress. Every syllable was a pressure point: say the right thing and the tension breaks. Say the wrong thing and there is that *almost* silence. That painful need to complete…

And when my teacher asked me to pick a hero to report on, I chose Columbus. The parallels are not lost on any middle schooler – stumbling into a world, hoping to discover meaning. A lost captain who thought he knew, but couldn't imagine.

But my teacher's Mayan ancestry, coiling around the double helix of her DNA like the ancient god, Kukulkan, sprouted fangs. She called me naïve. Insensitive. And asked if I would call Hitler a hero too? No, my voice cracked, he was a murderer.

I was sent to the hallway while she collected her thoughts. Later she would tell me it was a teachable moment. About history's one-sidedness, she said. About the cost of discovery. And I knew what she meant, but didn't mean.

And I felt very different from her.

Age 15

A beautiful girl said she like my sun kissed skin, adding heat to the burn in my cheeks. I told her that it always happens when I forget to wear sunscreen. She didn't burn. She glowed. The more she swam in sunlight, the more she became it. And I wanted to know. Why? I wanted to know. What makes a person burn and what makes a person glow?

What chemistry, or biology, or ideology makes two humans so different: a beautiful corn-rowed caramel and a red and white peppermint stick? So I asked her what she was. And the slap that followed made my ears ring and my eyes water.

But at least the burn hid the handprint.

Age 17

The night the theater lost power, we stumbled out into the darkness together. A sea of humanity, lead by flashlights: some people seemed nervous. But not me. Instead the beauty of simple silhouettes of disappointed moviegoers struck me. We had more in common then than just about any group of strangers I'd ever been a part of.

Finding the street, bathed in orange overhead lighting, the spell was broken. And as we headed back to my car, I remember seeing a group of kids who looked my age but looked nothing like me. They were walking toward us.

We didn't say anything. There wasn't a moment of panic or pause. It was a subtle shift in our direction and we crossed the street.

Telling ourselves that we would've needed to cross the street eventually. Telling them that their darkness is scarier than a theater with no light.

Age 20

Sinking even lower in my seat as she stood taller and taller to address the teacher. In sharp contrast:
Me: Hung over from the night before.
Her: Hung up on an assignment that was cursory and forgettable.

This isn't important. I say to myself. She doesn't need to make a big deal about this. She is just wasting time.

Still persistent, she decreed that a world literature class should include the works of – insert names full of accents and special symbols here. To at least introduce the idea that non-white writers exist.

The professor looked at the rest of us (all white). As if he was still one of us. And that nauseas feeling of us and them, surfaced again.

He tried to make the case that the curriculum was out of his hands. Not his call. That the works included were determined by the dean. At which point she asked, "Well, which old white dude is that?" The air is sucked out of the room. I felt a pull to sit up straighter. The teacher has gone from oppressive white to offended pale. He stammered and stuttered like he was trying to pronounce those special names and she didn't wait for the response. She grabbed her bag but left her fat book of dead white men and walked out of the room. I wanted to join her. I could've been the moth that gravitated toward her flame. But I stayed in my seat. What difference would it make?

Would it change the color of my bruises?
Would it remove the handprint under the burn?

Would it put me back on the right side of the street?
Or would I simply be playing the part
The white savior who could not understand
But thinks he could

The teacher shrugs.

The whitest response of all.

We return to our studies because privilege makes us immune to such displays.

And I worry about the days when I don't care about feeling different from her.

Georgia

She sings on the corner of 15th and Franklin. A popular spot at exactly two times per day: when I am trying to get to work and when I'm trying to get away from work. Both are a struggle for me.

She doesn't seem to have the same "employment problem"

She has grey at the temples, pronounced arthritis in her hands, and one outfit: a faded Georgia peach sweatshirt.

Every day, rain or shine, she is there.
She doesn't seem to be singing to anyone in particular, just loud hymnals to make us all aware that the blood of the lamb makes the sun shine bright – or something.

And on the day I got fired, I didn't have anywhere to go, but I left early.
In the elevator, all the way down, I wondered how I would face my family. How I would make my rent. How I would find the energy to get out of bed tomorrow.

When I heaved myself through the glass doors into the blinding and anonymous world, there she was. Sitting on the sidewalk. Singing.

"What are you doing here?"

"Singing," She said. As if *I* was the crazy one. "The world needs a little singing and I need a little singing and something tells me this is the spot to do it."

"That doesn't even make sense. Don't you have a home or a job? Don't you have things to do other than stand out here? Or are you too busy being homeless and useless to even *try* to make sense of this world?"

"Is that what you're doing? Making sense of this world? Because one of us is carrying his life in a box right now, and it ain't me."

"I just got fired. I just lost everything."

She saw me then. Saw exactly how small I was. How pathetic and pointless I was. So, she hugged me. I didn't want her to, but I needed her to. She hugged me until I started crying.

And she said "You're the reason I sing. Because there are so many people who lose things everyday. Jobs. Cars. Money. Homes. The matter that don't matter. Not everybody need to be a singer. But everybody need to find something to sing about."

She sent me on my way then. As I got further away, her song bounced off the buildings and snuck into my head. And just before 18th street, I looked back and she was gone. But For a moment I swear I saw her halo wink in the sunlight.